

Wide
Angle

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An interesting arrest was made in Mumbai a few weeks ago. A computer shop owner was arrested on charges of piracy. Yes, that is quite commonplace but do bear with me for a minute. The Intellectual Property (IP) being pirated was a copy of a recent mainstream movie featuring a certain “hot” actress. The real interesting part about this incident, is that the movie was in a compressed video format that 1) was not one that the owners of the IP would ever use, 2) could be exchanged freely, 3) would fit on a memory card and 4) was meant to be viewed on a Nokia 6600. That’s right! A full movie on a little phone, being traded on the dark side.

Admit it, you too have been guilty of doing the funny deed at some point. How often have you restrained your impulse to pass the merriment of a funny SMS to your friends? With cheap GPRS connectivity and GPRS capable phones cheaper by the day, how long before the SMS turns into e-mail with video attachments? Feature-packed phones have already shown the lowly PDA its place, and are currently busy kicking consumer grade cameras out of the market. With 5GB storage available

at source pulls content into the darknet before it has a chance to be DRM-wrapped.

To a practical media company, sharing isn’t bad as long as they get paid for their content. EMI intends to use our compulsive sharing drive to run what is being termed a “super-distribution” network in Europe, early next year. Super-distribution is a ‘viral’ network (in marketingspeak) that functions on the same general principle as shareware. You can pass on a copy of your favourite tune to your friends. They can preview the song as many times as they want, but after a fixed time period, they must purchase the song or it is automatically deleted. While EMI is the first major music distributor to run this experiment, you can go right now to <http://weedshare.com> to decide for yourself whether you find this transaction model interesting.

Either way, the cell phone is your next radio/TV/mediaplayer/gameboy/PDA/camera. Mobility will allow it to eventually be used for purposes beyond those of any deskbound PC. If access to content must be controlled, the battle for the hearts and minds of consumers will have to be won on the cell phone.

Share It, Please

Gadgets becoming smaller and more powerful could prove to an IPR nightmare unless the distribution format changes

on tiny 1-inch hard disk drives, digital media recording and playback is the next frontier. What do you think will happen when it is just as easy to receive and

forward a video clip, or a song or whatever? With the majority of current phones, you can exchange ringtones and wallpapers. You could potentially forward applications and games the same way, but basic forward-locks prevent you from doing so. Yet, you see mobile games being pirated all the time.

For cheap content, the media guys can live with simplistic protection schemes. But when high value content (read movies and music) comes into the picture, stiffer protection is demanded. This protection is currently available in the form of OMA DRM baked into the new crop of phones such as the Nokia 3220 (so, get together, but don’t really do whatever).

The basic premise for any digital content transaction is that both the consumer and the content provider have a set of needs that must be met. The content provider wants to be able to charge for the content, and control its use. The consumer on the other hand, must be able to access that content any way he wants, and transfer it around to any of his devices that are capable of displaying it, be they portable entertainment devices or a PC or the TV. To be successful, DRM solutions have work within that space. Of course, an unbreakable DRM has not yet been implemented and theft

Tearing down the wall around sharing content, allowing users to behave as they naturally would, and charging for the convenience of enabling that may be the only viable route for content providers to make money simply because even when they don’t make money, friendly neighbourhood file-sharers continue to make hay.

Search Redux

On a more practical note, two recently released free applications have shot to the top of my list at work. Firefox has been my default browser over its last few point releases, and the final version 1.0 just cements that position. Interestingly, it is my choice not because of what comes bundled in the installer, but because of what you can install later—a most useful set of extensions. Another tool, Google Desktop Search (GDS) almost made me drop Firefox. The unique thing about GDS is its ability to index documents as you access them, even web pages, but only if you use Internet Explorer (IE). The ability to search through my browser history is an invaluable research tool, so IE was back on my list. Then came the discovery of Slogger, an extension for Firefox that saves every page you view in the browser to a specified folder (it can also save as selectively as you want). When the page is written to disk, GDS indexes it immediately and voila—problem solved. There are alternatives to GDS that handle more file-types (by the way, look up GDS Plus at <http://www.trivex.net/>) but GDS does the ones I use with a super simple browser interface, so it stays. ■

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